



Nepal



Nepal, lying between India and China on the southern shoulder of the Himalayas, is one of the world's poorest countries. Its agricultural economy is heavily dependent on the monsoon.



GEOGRAPHY

Mainly mountainous. The area includes some of the highest mountains in the world, including Mount Everest. Flat, fertile river plains form the south.



CLIMATE

Warm monsoon season from July to October. The rest of the year is dry, sunny, and mild. Winter temperatures in the Himalayas average 14°F (−10°C).



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Tensions are few between the diverse ethnic groups. Buddhist women, including Sherpas, face fewer social restrictions than Hindus. Trafficking of women and child labor are problems. Human rights violations rose during the 1999–2006 Maoist insurgency. The peace deal led to the abolition of the monarchy and Maoist victory in elections, but fractious coalitions mean instability continues.



THE ECONOMY

Agriculture employs 70% of people. Crops include rice and wheat. Tourism and investment affected by instability and Maoist insurgency. Reliant on aid. Hydropower potential.



INSIGHT: Southern Nepal was the birthplace of Buddha (Prince Siddhartha Gautama) in 563 BCE



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Federal Democratic Republic of Nepal

DATE OF FORMATION: 1769

CAPITAL: Kathmandu

POPULATION: 29.3 million

TOTAL AREA: 54,363 sq. miles (140,800 sq. km)

DENSITY: 555 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Nepali*, Maithili, Bhojpuri

RELIGIONS: Hindu 90%, Buddhist 5%, Muslim 3%, other (incl. Christian) 2%

ETHNIC MIX: Other 57%, Chhetri 16%, Hill Brahman 13%, Tharu 7%, Magar 7%

GOVERNMENT: Transitional regime

CURRENCY: Nepalese rupee = 100 paisa